

Skipper Chong Warson

San Francisco Bay Area

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Product, service design, and strategy leader with 15+ years across startups, product studios, and complex organizations. I help teams turn messy customer and stakeholder evidence into clearer product, service, and strategic decisions. Built and led a distributed 12-person Americas design team generating \$2.1M in annual billable work, shaped 125 enterprise pre-sales opportunities, helped run a 20-person product studio, and led work from discovery and service design through prototypes, design systems, and implementation. I use AI as leverage to work across larger evidence sets, accelerate synthesis, and make research easier to retrieve and reuse while keeping human judgment and direct customer evidence at the center.

EXPERIENCE

How This Works co, Remote

Aug 2024–present

Principal advisor, founder

Built and run an advisory practice helping founding teams turn customer evidence into decisions about audience, positioning, product direction, and what to do next.

- Developed and delivered 11 Bullseye Customer Sprints, three follow-on Listening Cycles, and seven other client projects, bringing founders, product leaders, and engineers into live interviews and debriefs so firsthand evidence shapes product and go-to-market decisions
- Led Replay through five customer hypothesis cycles, including 34 structured interviews within nearly 50 customer conversations; evidence helped narrow audience, positioning, and product direction
- Built a Claude-based research archive from redacted source materials so teams could query findings while tracing answers back to the underlying customer evidence

SoftServe, Remote

Jan 2021–Jul 2024

Regional design director, Americas

Led design strategy, business development, team growth, and consulting delivery for the Americas design group, bringing greater service design rigor into complex enterprise engagements. Promoted three times.

- Directed an 18-month Duke Energy program with a six-person core team inside a 40-person group; led research and synthesis across 70+ initiatives and developed visual frameworks leaders used to focus deeper work on roughly 20; translated those priorities into dashboards, tracking tools, communications, facility concepts, an implementation roadmap, and two working prototypes; expanded an initial 12-week discovery into 18+ months of commissioned follow-on work
- Built and managed a distributed 12-person design team across the U.S., Canada, Mexico, Colombia, and Chile, including two people managers; owned hiring, performance reviews, promotions, compensation recommendations, and career development for a group generating \$2.1M in annual billable work
- Designed a staffing and DesignOps structure supporting approximately 200 designers outside the Americas team, mapping skills and capabilities against project needs to support staffing decisions
- Shaped 125 enterprise pre-sales opportunities, including 25+ RFP responses

thoughtbot, San Francisco, CA

Aug 2019–Dec 2020

Studio design director

Helped lead a 20-person product development studio, directly managing three team members while shaping discovery, product strategy, and early-stage client engagements.

- Co-managed staffing, project health, sales qualification, staff development, and studio operations; coached designers through one-on-ones, critiques, and team rituals while strengthening design-engineering collaboration
- Co-led approximately 50 early-stage and enterprise opportunity conversations, helping teams clarify customer problems, product strategy, MVP scope, validation plans, design sprints, and proofs of concept

Shep, Remote

Apr 2017–Dec 2021

Founding product design director

Worked ~10 hours a month as a fractional design and product lead through the company's shift into enterprise travel, the collapse of business travel, and its 2021 acquisition by Flight Centre.

- Shaped product and design direction through leadership meetings, working sessions, and backlog reviews; hired and directed two contract designers for the 2020 rebuild of the website, browser extension, and related product experience
- Translated the duty-of-care strategy into traveler guidance for health advisories, policy exceptions, emergency assistance, and traveler support; backed enterprise pilots with Adidas and Discovery Channel

Sesame, New York, NY

Sep 2018–Aug 2019

Founding product design director

Joined as the first in-house design hire and helped take a direct-pay healthcare marketplace from early mobile prototypes through a Jan 2019 conference prototype and subsequent beta launch in Kansas City.

- Ran 21 customer interviews and prototype tests and iterated provider-side concepts with a physician advisory council; combined live observation with Hotjar recordings to revise booking and shopping flows within days
- Built Macaw, a Figma design system connected to Storybook through Chromatic with the front-end architect; the product launched on schedule, reaching approximately 500 providers by Aug 2019

Fjord, New York, NY

Aug 2013–Sep 2018

Senior service designer

Completed 20+ engagements across North America and Europe spanning customer research, service design, facilitation, product strategy, and opportunity framing at Fjord/Accenture. Promoted twice.

- Led two Bank of America engagements: unifying banker experiences across 10+ business lines and consolidating three research applications into an internal iOS product for portfolio managers, traders, and analysts
- Co-led TTC/Metrolinx contactless fare work with 100+ stakeholder and user interviews, 20+ field visits, hardware/software prototypes, and 50 usability sessions
- For a Fortune 500 company's healthcare-financing unit, led research and service design supporting a business case projecting 10% higher signups and approximately \$2M in annual retained revenue

Earlier independent design work, Austin, TX + New York, NY*Web and graphic designer*

Design work for PBS FRONTLINE, Mediabistro, Rx.com, and Keller Williams HQ through GSD&M, T3, and directly.

EDUCATION

altMBA, developed by Seth Godin

2016

Completed the program, then organized New York City meetups, 2016–2019

The University of Texas at El Paso

BA

Double major in playwriting and English literature, 3.8 GPA

CERTIFICATIONS

Six Sigma Black Belt, Council for Six Sigma Certification

2024

Facilitator training, AJ&Smart

2021

ADVISORY

- Mentor, Startup Grind, Entrepreneurs Roundtable Accelerator (ERA), Venture Mechanics, and Startup Foundry
- Advisory board member, ReCity Labs
- Leadership coach